

“Change is the Only Constant”

A Multi-Modal Analysis of Voter Desire for ‘Change’ in US Elections

Background & Motivation

The stagnation of real wages and the consequences of a globalized society have created conditions of distress in a segment of the US electorate. The examination of the voting behaviour of this specific segment is crucial because this segment:

- 1) Will grow in size as economic disparity worsens
- 2) Is relatively unconcerned with ideology = Swing Voter
- 3) Is ‘distressed’ = susceptible to manipulation/ rhetoric

Research Question

Can we identify a hypothetical voter who is motivated by a desire for ‘change’ (beyond anti-incumbency) and can we model their affinity for candidates that embody ‘change’?



Study One: How do Candidates embody ‘Change’?

Methodology

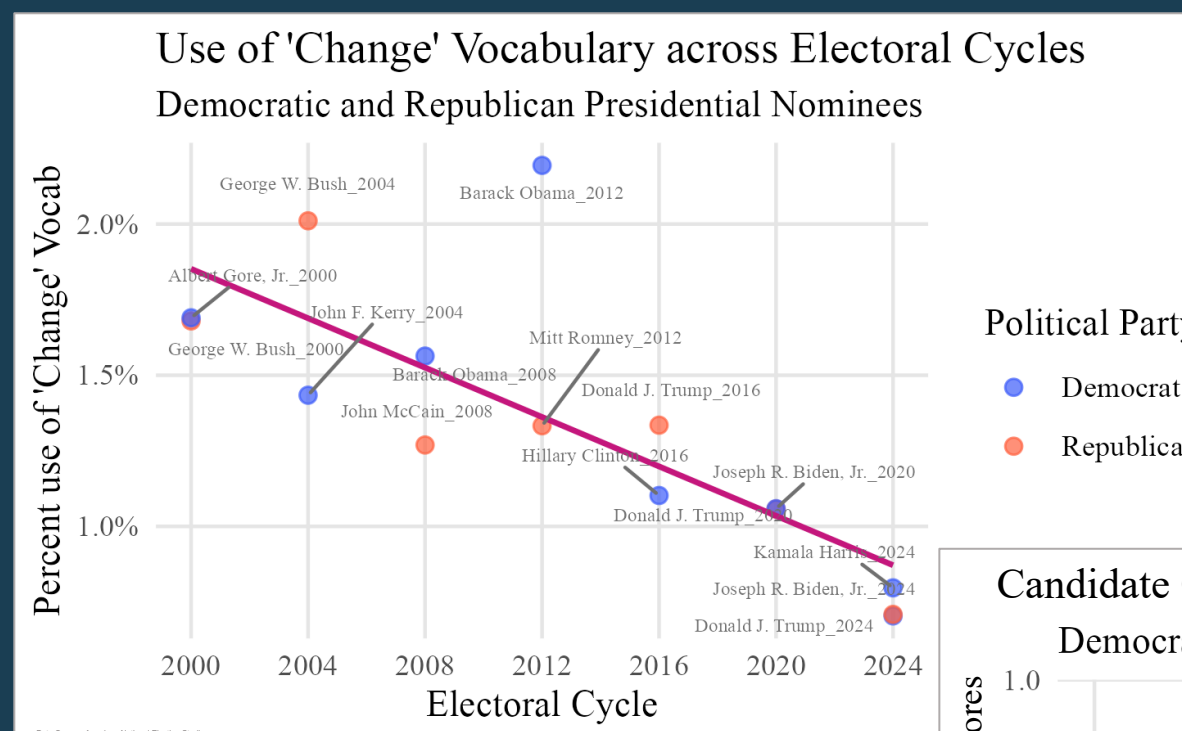
Quantify the degree of ‘change’ that each presidential candidate embodies, using:

- 1) **Rhetoric:** Vocabulary Frequency Analysis of ‘change’ messaging in campaign rallies, interviews, press releases
- 2) **Attributes:** Gender, Ethnic Minority, Age, Governmental Career, Party Affiliation, Relative to Incumbent, Political Dynasty

**Rhetoric + Attributes
=
Candidate Change Score**

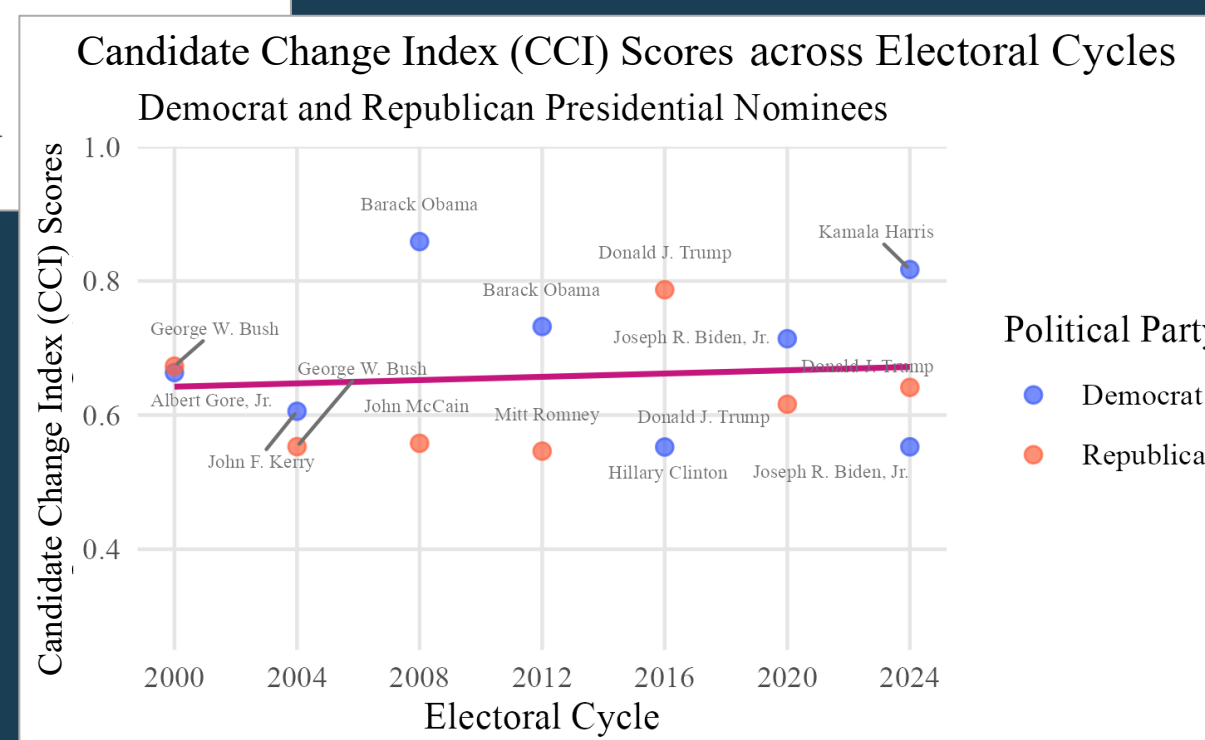
Results: Rhetoric

- Candidates in *both* parties make use of ‘change’ messaging
-> no partisan ownership of ‘change’
- Downward Trend observed
-> Decreasing use of ‘change’ rhetoric over time



Results: Candidate Change Index (CCI)

- Trend: Slight increase in ‘change’ embodied by candidates
- Explained by profile of candidates that now run for office:
 - More minority representation, women, true political outsiders
 - Embody change so evidently = less reliance on heavy rhetoric to communicate their ‘change’ appeal



Study Two: Which attributes define a ‘Change Voter’?

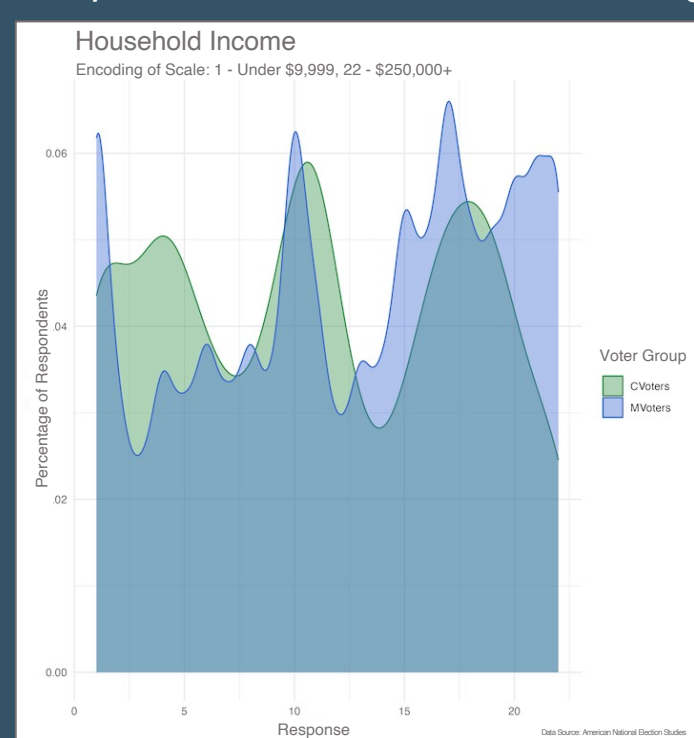
Methodology

- 1) Using survey data from *American National Election Studies*, identify respondents who voted in the pattern:
->[2012: Obama]
->[2016: Trump]
->[2020: Biden]
- 2) Determine Attributes unique to these ‘Change Voters’ (CVoters) relative to all other voters (MVoters) using Statistical Tests of Independence

Results Twenty survey variables are found to be Distributionally Independent for CVoters. From these, we draw three broad themes.

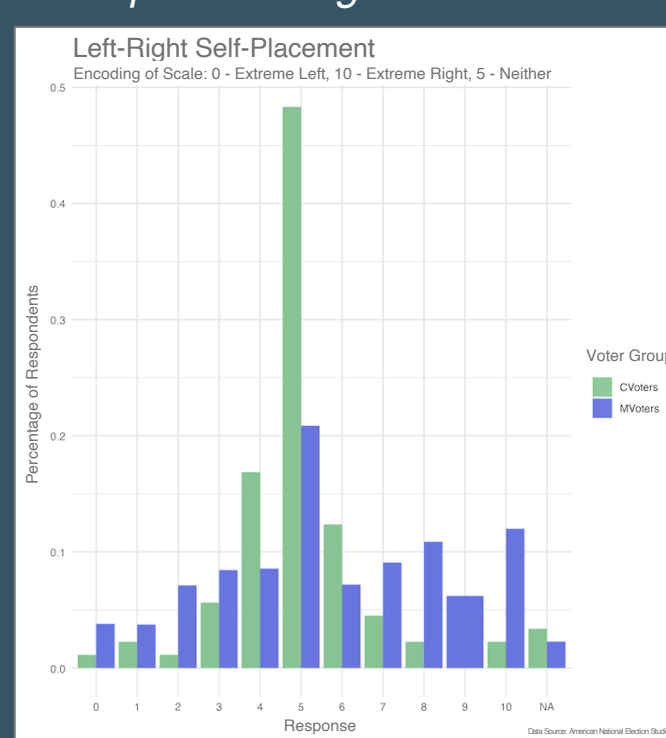
1 Economic

CVoters have **Worse** Economic Situations and Perceptions of Economy.
Example: \$7,000 lower Income on avg.



2 Pol. Alignment

CVoters feel **Non-Alignment** with Established Parties and Ideology.
Example: Left-Right Self-Placement



3 Information Level

CVoters are **not Low-Information** voters.

- CVoters on average correctly identify political offices of Pelosi, Merkel, SCOTUS Roberts
- In contrast with original hypothesis

Theory Formulation: Towards a ‘Change Voter’ Phenotype

Observing our *Economic, Ideological, and Informational* results, we formulate a single, unified ‘Theory of Change Voters’, which describes:

- 1) *Persistent Economic Distress,*
- 2) *Conscious Political Non-Alignment,*
- 3) *Standard Information Levels.*

Study Three: Testing our ‘Theory of Change Voters’

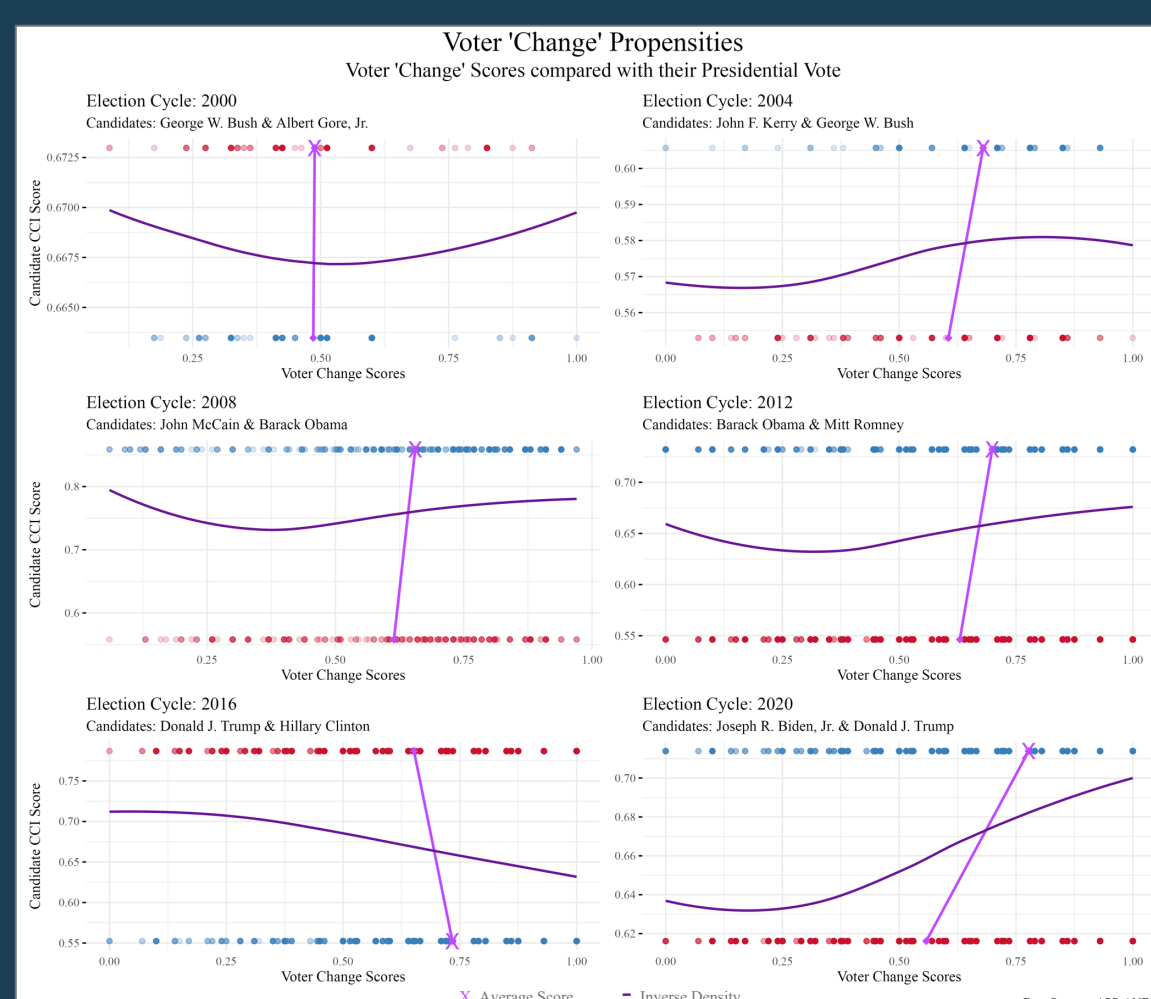
Methodology

Score each voter based on their affinity for ‘change’ using:

- Perception of Income Gap
- Centrist Political Self-Placement
- Information Levels

**Change Voter Score
=
(0.5 * ECON) +
(0.35 * LEFTRIGHT) +
(0.15 * INFORMED)**

Results: Do voters with higher Change Voter Scores vote for Change Candidates?



- For five out of six elections, voters with higher Voter Change Scores are more likely to pick the Change Candidate
 - Theory Validation Rate of 5/6
- Outlier of Clinton/Trump explained by
 - Clinton being first female presidential candidate ever
 - Poor surveying in ‘16

Conclusions

The phenomenon of a ‘Change Voter’ describes a voter experience of **persistent economic dissatisfaction** and **conscious non-alignment**, that votes for candidates in a manner more complex than a simple anti-incumbency. Crucially, these voters are **politically informed**, opening the door for questions on the effects of rhetoric and misinformation on this growing group of swing voters in the United States.